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China Auto Industry

Highlights from BYD and Geely meetings at EU Auto Conference

- Rising representation of Chinese OEMs in Europe:** We attended J.P. Morgan's annual European auto conference in London (June 1-2) and hosted panel discussions for BYD, Geely and Chery Auto. Other participating global OEMs include Benz, BMW, Volkswagen, Renault, Nissan, Volvo, Daimler Truck and from several global suppliers. Across all panels, China repeatedly was a center of focus- including *1) Chinese OEMs' overseas expansion and the implications for global OEMs and suppliers, 2) global OEMs' strategies to leverage either their China product or cost advantage of China business to the global market-* or so-called "In China and for Global" approach cited by global players. At the conference, BYD, Geely and Chery displayed the latest models (Figures 1-3). We also managed to visit BYD's showroom at Canary Wharf station.
- What surprised us** is the speed of overseas volume growth of Chinese brands, driven by competitive product offerings, various powertrain options (BEV, PHEV and HEV), superior interior content (vs. foreign brands in the same price category) and aggressive channel expansion. Among our coverage, we see potential upside to our current overseas volume estimates: BYD potentially topping 1.7-1.8mn units (JPMe current 1.5mn) and Geely Auto ~1.0mn units (JPMe 750k).
- Highlight 1:** For BYD and Geely, overseas product strategy is shifting from single-powertrain exports to a portfolio plus brand/tech story, with Europe treated as a mixed-propulsion transition market. For instance, BYD targets a BEV/PHEV balance and plans 2H26 PHEV launches (Dolphin and Aito DMi SUV) while premium brand "Denza" in 2H26 will be a strategic move (starting MSRP ~GBP80k) where Geely emphasizes AI integrated into ADAS.
- Highlight 2:** On expansion strategy, BYD prioritizes dense coverage (2,000 dealers/stores in Europe by end-2026) and claims 45–50% test-drive conversion; Geely has an "asset-light approach," leveraging partners (e.g. Lynk&Co via Volvo). All Chinese OEMs emphasize after-sales depth and dealer confidence to build trust, residual values, and monthly-payment competitiveness.
- Highlight 3:** Localization/footprint signals split strategies. Geely's path is partnership/KD-led (e.g. Renault Korea KD parts, Renault Brazil cooperation) and anchored by Malaysia Proton JV (Geely owns 49.9% stake). BYD cites its goal is to bring the latest flash-charging and blade battery technology to Europe in 2H26, initially through Denza premium products.

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Highlights of Chinese OEMs' participation in J.P. Morgan's Annual European Auto Conference

We summarize key takeaways from Chinese OEMs' comments at the conference below.

1) Chinese OEMs' latest overseas product strategy (BEV/PHEV/HEV mix, brands, charging, software)

Meeting highlights pointed to product strategies that are being adapted for overseas markets through powertrain mix, brand architecture, and "supporting" product propositions like charging solutions and software, rather than relying on a single headline advantage. BYD is explicit that Europe requires a broader powertrain approach than pure BEV-only positioning, while Geely's emphasis is more concentrated on software-led competitiveness and packaging that with an "asset-light" go-to-market model.

BYD

BYD's Europe product strategy is framed around maintaining a BEV and PHEV balance in Europe, with specific PHEV launches in 2H26 (Dolphin and Aito DMi SUV). BYD's overseas brand architecture is also positioned as multi-tiered, explicitly described as BYD, Denza, and Yang Wang, implying a deliberate laddering of brand positioning rather than a single-brand export approach. The product planning cadence is described as a 3–4 year model cycle, and BYD also notes that older buyers value functionality, which signals a willingness to tune feature prioritization to buyer demographics and practical needs.

Charging is most directly and concretely addressed by BYD, and it functions as both an ownership proposition and a commercialization lever. BYD states it will deploy a flash-charging network in the UK from September this year, and BYD states a target of 3,000 flash-charging posts in Europe by end-2026. We believe that if BYD is able to execute to that scale, the charging rollout could support conversion and acceptance by reducing perceived friction for first-time buyers and fleets, and it could also help reinforce BYD's stated desire to avoid price competition by improving the overall value proposition beyond sticker price alone.

BYD's broader product positioning is explicitly tied to residual-value discipline: BYD explicitly states it aims to avoid price competition to protect residual value, and it ties buyer decision-making to monthly payments and residual value.

Geely Auto

Geely's most explicit product and technology highlight in the meeting was software-led: Geely is cited as integrating AI into ADAS. Geely strategically concentrates on an "asset-light" business model by partnering with selected global OEMs in different markets- including Renault in Korea and Brazil as well as Porton in Malaysia.

2) Distribution and go-to-market strategy (channels, store footprints, fleet, partnerships)

Distribution strategies differ by company in terms of how to build access, trust, and after-sales credibility in overseas markets while scaling at speed. BYD's approach emphasizes a large dealer/store target plus measurable conversion, while Geely's approach emphasizes partnerships and an "asset-light" posture that leverages existing channels.

BYD's go-to-market plan in Europe is anchored by physical scale and conversion performance. BYD is targeting 2,000 dealers and stores in Europe by end-2026, and BYD's stated test-drive conversion is 45–50%.

BYD's UK channel emphasis includes fleet-sales plus retail, and UK supply shortage is cited as a current operational constraint given overwhelming demand. BYD indicated it is gaining share from Benz, BMW, and Tesla.

Geely's distribution posture is positioned differently, with a heavier emphasis on partnerships and channel leverage as a way to scale with lower asset intensity. Geely describes an "asset-light approach" to overseas expansion, e.g. Lynk&Co distribution is run via the Volvo channel. Mgmt also mentioned its UK Galaxy launch as a near-term go-to-market action, and Zeekr BEV success in Hong Kong also enhances the company's confidence in premium business in Europe.

3) Overseas volume, exports, and market share momentum

At the conference, BYD emphasized absolute overseas scale and targets, while Geely emphasized export scale with explicit accounting boundaries (exports versus CKD) and an "asset-light" frame.

Geely Auto

Geely's export ambition includes a 2026 export target of 750k units, with May exports having topped 85k.

In addition, Geely also exports through CKD suggesting Geely is managing multiple routes to overseas market and is intentionally tracking "export" distinctly from knock-down assembly pathways, which can be read as flexibility in how volume is delivered internationally even when headline "export" reporting is bounded.

BYD

BYD's scale narrative is framed in larger absolute terms. BYD year-to-date exports are above 600k, and BYD's 2026 overseas sales guidance is 1.5mn units.

In addition, BYD also focuses on residual-value discipline and charging-network ambitions, implying that BYD is trying to couple volume growth with a value proposition that supports monthly-payment competitiveness rather than competing purely on upfront price.

Across Chinese OEMs, we also notice that powertrain mix is being used as a commercialization tool in Europe. BYD states it is aiming for a BEV and PHEV balance in Europe.

4) Overseas localization, production footprint, and “asset-light” vs “on-the-ground” approaches

One distinct business model difference in overseas markets is BYD focusing on vertical integration vs. Geely’s more asset light approach:

Geely’s overseas capacity plan is partnership-oriented. Mgmt highlighted Geely’s Renault Korea KD parts as Geely’s overseas industrial footprint and partnership approach, and the Renault Brazil cooperation was also discussed at the conference. Geely further cited a Malaysia Proton JV (49.6% ownership by Geely) as an overseas market-access and operational anchor. In other words, Geely believes in expansion through cooperation structures, KD pathways, and channel leverage rather than a fully owned, full-stack manufacturing rollout.

BYD, on the other hand, has been building several plants outside China- Thailand plant was completed in 2024, and Brazil earlier this year, whilst Hungary is in the process.

Recommendations

Our investment conclusion in China is straightforward: **1) focus on key NEV plays** with high or fast-growing overseas revenue: BYD (~50–60%), Geely (~40%), XPeng (~20%) on JPMe, whilst avoiding state-owned OEMs, including JVs. **2) Focus on OEMs with superior 2Q26 QoQ or 2H26 HoH growth.** 3) Focus on companies with earnings upside surprise- Geely Auto.

We reiterate our preference for BYD, Geely, followed by Leapmotor, XPeng and NIO, while maintaining reservations on SAIC, Guangzhou Auto, Brilliance China, Li Auto and Changan Auto.

Figure 1: BYD Denza premium car (scheduled to debut in UK and EU in 2H26, with starting MSRP ~GBP80k)



Source: Photo taken at J.P. Morgan Auto Conference

Figure 2: Chery Auto's new SUV (Jaecoo) in UK



Source: Photo taken at J.P. Morgan Auto Conference

Figure 3: Geely's upcoming Galaxy BEV in UK and EU



Source: Photo taken at J.P. Morgan Auto Conference

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